

RELIGION

In the 16th century, a German monk, Martin Luther, attacked the teachings of the Roman Catholic Church in Germany, preaching his own brand of Christianity. The movement he started was called the Reformation, and his followers, Protestants. His movement gained most support in northern Germany, which is still largely Protestant. Most people in southern Germany are Catholic.



This Gutenberg Bible was printed in Germany.

SPORTS

Many of the world's top sports stars have come from Germany, including Boris Becker in tennis, brothers Michael (shown right) and Ralf Schumacher (shown left) in motor racing, and Katja Seizinger in skiing. Soccer is Germany's most popular spectator sport. The West German team was outstandingly successful, winning the World Cup several times. A single, unified German squad first entered competition for the 1992 European Cup.



THE ECONOMY

Germany's industries were completely rebuilt and modernized after World War II. Today, Germany is one of the world's leading industrial nations. This success is largely due to its very strong manufacturing industry. Germany is one of the world's top producers of trucks, ships, electrical goods and cars, with such famous names as Volkswagen, Mercedes, and BMW. These are exported for sale all over the world.



Foreign workers often took unskilled jobs that Germans were unwilling to do.

NEW GERMANS

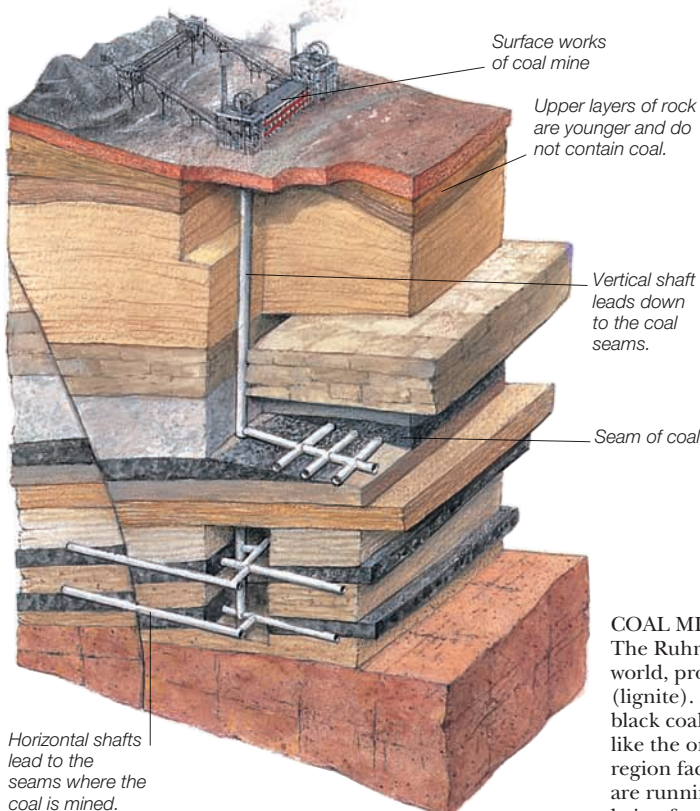
As the German economy grew, so did the need for labor. In the 1960s, thousands of people came from Turkey and former Yugoslavia to work in Germany. Life has not been easy for them. They have suffered discrimination and been refused citizenship, despite their contribution to German life. Since 1990, more than a million German-speaking immigrants have arrived from eastern Europe.



Around a third of German workers are employed in industry.

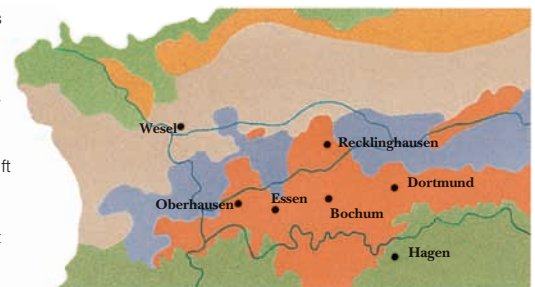
Cross-section through a deep coal mine

Coal deposits, or seams, are removed from the Earth by mining.



Coalfields in the Ruhr Valley

- Current coalfields
- Exhausted surface coalfields
- Coal reserves more than 3,300 ft (1,000 m) deep
- Coal reserves less than 3,300 ft (1,000 m) deep



THE RUHR VALLEY

The Ruhr Valley is the most heavily industrialized region in Germany, and also the most densely populated area, with many large towns and cities. In the 19th century, huge deposits of coal were discovered here. This led to the region's development as the center of iron and steel production, vital for Germany's car industry. At first, coal was mined in the south of the coalfield where it lay near the surface. These seams are now exhausted. Today, mining is concentrated in deeper mines in the north.

COAL MINING

The Ruhr coalfield is one of the largest in the world, producing both black coal and brown coal (lignite). Brown coal is found on the surface, but black coal has to be extracted from deep mines, like the one shown here. Today, the Ruhr region faces serious problems. Coal supplies are running out and other sources of fuel are being found, leaving many people without jobs.

Find out more

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